To the Chair and Committee members of Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

Introduction

This is the Voices of Wannon [VoW] submission to the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters. VoW is a group of community members from the electorate of Wannon in western Victoria. We came together in late 2021 to help make a meaningful connection between the people of Wannon and our political representatives. We are not a political party.

We are citizens from a wide range of backgrounds from across the electorate of Wannon who have become disaffected with party politics. Through community consultation we are gathering the diverse views of the Wannon electorate and advocating to ensure our common values are represented conscientiously in parliament by those we elect.

We expect high standards from our political leaders.

We are committed to advocating for representation that is an honest, meaningful and transparent consultative process between the electorate and our elected representatives. To date we have spoken with a proportion of voters in the electorate. Ongoing conversations are required to elicit and understand the views of Wannon voters.

More information about VoW can be found here https://www.voicesofwannon.net/

VoW members were active during the 2022 and 2025 federal election campaigns, indeed for this year's election, we were active from August 2024 until May 3 2025. During the 2025 campaign, VoW had 1000 volunteers actively participating in a wide range of activities right across the electorate of Wannon in support of the [redacted] candidate [redacted]. VoW volunteers acted as individuals who themselves chose to assist the [redacted]'s campaign. We were present at every pre-polling and polling place in Wannon in the weeks before the election.

All volunteers (including those who are members of VoW) signed a Code of Conduct issued by the [redacted] campaign team (attached[1]) covering their involvement in all aspects of campaigning. Very close attention was paid by all of us to ensure that all VoW volunteers who participated in the campaign abided by this code of conduct.

However, as we shall see, others active in the campaign did not all behave in these ways.

[1] See Appendix A

Feedback from Voices of Wannon members

We make a submission to your inquiry setting out a range of events which occurred before and during the 2025 federal election campaign which are of concern to us, and ask the Committee to make recommendations in order to try to prevent such occurrences from happening during [and before] political campaigns in the future.

In order to report to the Inquiry VoW volunteers VoW Secretary [redacted] sought feedback from all VoW volunteers and active supporters in an email on September 8 2025.

> Dear supporter
>
> I am emailing you on behalf of Voices of Wannon as you volunteered to help at a polling booth during [redacted]'s campaign.
>
> Whilst Voices of Wannon didn't run the campaign, we are very interested in improving the democratic process for everyone in Wannon. As such, we are preparing a group submission to a parliamentary inquiry into the conduct of the 2025 election. It would be excellent to add your voice to this submission.
>
> The inquiry is looking at many issues, including:
> - a purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and AEC officials
> - potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the capacity of the AEC to manage and address poor behaviour
>
> Further details are available via this link, which also includes a link directly to the full terms of reference for the inquiry.
>
> If you had any negative experiences while you were on a polling booth, or have any suggestions as to how the entire process might be improved, please let us know. Reply to this email and we will add your thoughts to a Voices of Wannon group submission. You could also make a direct (individual) submission to the inquiry, but if you would prefer to add to our group submission, we'd greatly appreciate it. (Or you could do both!)
>
> Please respond by 13 September so that we have time to collate a submission.
>
> Thank you for helping to ensure our elections stay free, fair and fun.

A selection of the responses to [redacted]'s request are included below. All quotations are the actual words of responders from Wannon VoW members who acted as [redacted] campaign volunteers. Specific identification details for each statement are available

from VoW Secretary [redacted].[2] As Committee members will see, many of the submissions relate directly to one, two or three of the above matters in integrated ways. Therefore, we choose to respond these three Terms of Reference together:

The first three of your terms of reference are set out below:

That the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters inquire into and report on all aspects of the conduct of the 2025 federal election and related matters, including consideration of the following:

- *assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials;*

- *potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;*

- *the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements*

Essentially, we see that these criteria seek to understand whether current provisions and laws and regulations relating to the design, regulation and maintenance of voter, volunteer and Australian Electoral Commission staff behaviour and security at pre-polling and polling places in Australia and internationally, are fit for purpose or need to be revised and changed. These quotations reflected our members' experiences:

"Please report that I had (at least) two [redacted] signs stolen from my front garden by a well-known [redacted] supporter, and that my front garden water tap was turned on causing a major increase in my water bill."

"I was really shocked by the whole atmosphere that was generated by "the [redacted]" team takeover of the whole site. It definitely did not have a Democracy Sausage kind of vibe at all. I was shocked and very intimidated. The Brethren are quite the "storm Troopers" for the [redacted]."

"Below is a copy of a letter that I sent to the local newspaper in Ararat, ***The Advocate*** just after the 2025 Wannon election outcome! I then asked ***The Advocate*** team to delete the letter and not publish it in their Letters to the Editor, out of respect for [redacted], who always distanced himself from the negative attacks coming from [redacted] and his team! However, I strongly feel that it is relevant feedback in relation to what you are requesting.

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[2] VoW Secretary [redacted]

"As an [redacted] campaign volunteer in Ararat, I got to witness firsthand the appalling lies the [redacted] campaign launched against him. The posters they displayed, included photos of him [redacted], but the [redacted] were presenting them as FACTS! Many voters believed that the photos were a true depiction of who [redacted] was, as a person!
The most effective lie, politically, was that [redacted] gave the finger to the police. I can assure you, [redacted] is a decent person and he was only [redacted]! That particular photo was from 15 years ago. [redacted] would never personally disrespect the police or the military. I had voters approach me in my role as a volunteer, throughout the campaign, who were furious that [redacted] was disrespecting the police and the military. They asserted, passionately, that they would NEVER vote for [redacted], because of those posters!
After I explained the truth to them, they immediately understood that the posters were lies, and they changed their opinion!
But there were countless other voters who we never got to have that conversation with, and who would have continued to believe the [redacted] lies!.
...I am personally appalled that the AEC approved those posters by the [redacted], without fact checking them, first. I believe that the lies on the posters were successful in manipulating voters, and were effective in influencing the election outcome.
What would the ultimate election outcome have been, if those posters had been rejected by the AEC, and voters were only making decisions based on policy differences?
When I was volunteering at the pre-polling booth, one of the [redacted] volunteers approached me, expressing total disgust at the poster that [redacted]'s campaign displayed, showing a pot hole in the road.
Yet, when we went campaign door knocking, the state of the roads was the number 1 issue that most voters raised with us! Yes, [redacted] was attacking [redacted]'s poor record on fixing the roads, but it was not a personal attack and it was not based on LIES!
[redacted] has had 15 years to fix the roads [redacted] They could have helped him financially, easily. But, IMO, as Wannon was considered to be a safe [redacted] seat, they probably spent the available funds within the more marginalised electorates.
It was disturbing that [redacted] actually ran his 2025 campaign on a pledge to fix the roads, as per the sign, his campaign displayed in High St., near Reece Plumbing, when he had already had 15 years to fix the problem!
We need integrity in our election system and lies should not be permitted as a way of crushing a political opponent!
IMO, [redacted] was allowed to do this, and it worked for him!
Our federal election outcome proves that we still have some integrity in our system! But it needs to be protected and fortified!
We don't want to end up like the USA! Here are the posters, [redacted]"[3]

[3] The text and images in these large signs also formed a series of full-colour mail out leaflets which were received by all Wannon households. They contain false and misleading information and were authorised by the [redacted] and thus to [redacted]. Campaign materials like these - of a deceptive and malicious nature - of which there was a very large amount distributed in Wannon, were not linked to any other candidate or party standing for election.

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"Thanks for the opportunity to give feedback
In my days at the pre poll the week prior to election day, I was disgusted and astounded at the behaviour of some of the people assisting the [redacted] campaign and supporting candidate [redacted]. I will be up front and outrightly say that these individuals were not '[redacted] locals' who were there to support their local candidate but very obviously had been brought in to 'represent' the candidate but unfortunately in an aggressive and divisive manner.
These people were, I have no doubt from the Brethren religious group. There were a couple of young men who were rude, intimidating and aggressive. I did complain to one of [redacted]'s senior staff on election day and they were very aware of what was going on.

[redacted] was obviously very concerned of his position in the campaign so agreed to allow these people to come in. It previously was not [redacted] style but panic of losing the election obviously pushed him to agree with this. It was a disgrace
On election day it was the same arrogant couple of people where I was at Warrnambool Primary School. Disgraceful behaviour. Pushing right up beside other party/ candidate supporters. I had one of the Brethren people laughing at me while I was talking to voters and interrupting and pushing over the lines we were to stand behind.
I spoke to them and asked them to back off, to only be laughed at and ridiculed.
The 'real' [redacted] supporters, who I have no issue with, were obviously embarrassed and perturbed with the aggressive and uncomfortable situation.
Normally at pre poll or on election day, candidates' supporters giving out how to vote information all seem to chat amongst everyone and get on ok.
It was a disgraceful and disappointing experience
Luckily there was great support from the [redacted] team and other candidates' supporters.
There was actually an article last week in ***The Age*** about this'.[4]"

"..it's a shame that the terms of reference don't include the use by some parties of slurs, lies and derogatory comments in all forms of media. That is what I would like to see addressed."

"I was a volunteer for the [redacted] Campaign in the recent 2025 Federal Election. My experience at these events is most often collegial and friendly at pre-poll. On this occasion however, in Portland (the seat of Wannon in South West Vic) it was marred by a woman who displayed great anger, rudeness and resentment that I should be there at all, supporting the [redacted] candidate.
When I came to stand with '[redacted]', a [redacted] volunteer, to hand out our respective pamphlets, I cordially introduced myself in a happy, friendly way which is my nature. When '[redacted]' did not turn around to acknowledge my arrival or my happy greeting, I thought that being older, she had not heard me...I was very wrong. '[redacted]', on my second attempt at greeting, turned slowly around and said, "Why would I want to talk to you?"
Here I was a 63-year-old woman, trying to be friendly and converse happily with another woman that I ascertained may have been a little older than me.

'[redacted]' would not give me her name (I found out from one of her fellow [redacted] volunteers later, what it was.) When I suggested that there were many other things we could talk about like gardening or movies or how beautiful Portland was, she refused to answer or acknowledge me in any way. I said to her, "I'm so sorry you feel you must be rude and need to ignore me in this way. We are here together for quite a while. It would be better to find things in common to talk about rather than be unfriendly and exhibit hostility."

After approximately an hour of handing out, during which I witnessed '[redacted]'s' lovely friendly disposition with the voters who passed by, I went to share some lollies I had brought to share. As I offered them to [redacted], she nearly forgot to remain unfriendly and reached to have one, then retracted her hand and reminded me that "I am here to support [redacted] and do a job, I am not interested in speaking with you, or being your friend. Do not speak to me".

[redacted]

When my shift was finished, I went to her friendlier colleague to ask what '[redacted]'s name was and as I left in my car, I rolled down the window and said 'Good bye [redacted], I hope you enjoy the rest of your day'. [redacted] was somewhat shocked that I had found out what her name was, still she did not reply!

On another occasion during the Election period, it came to my attention via a [redacted] party volunteer that some of the so called 'volunteers' from the [redacted] party at various booths were being paid to hand out 'how to vote' pamphlets and were not volunteers at all. $30 per hour was mentioned.

Two [female volunteers for our campaign] were "... intimidated and felt overwhelmed by The Plymouth Brethren members who came to set up at pre-poll in Warrnambool. It was about 6:30 am when we started to set up and the "big bulky Plymouth men, behaving like thugs barged in over them. They were aggressive and blocked their access. It reminded [our volunteers] of how the 'far right' people were behaving in Melbourne recently...They were verbally aggressive as well, both in the pre-poll at Warrnambool and at Jamison St Primary school on polling day..."

At Jamison Street Primary School, this behaviour was repeated on Polling Day and so shocked the recent [redacted] ([redacted]) that she reported it to the AEC people working there.

The Plymouth Brethren were found handing out 'how to vote' pamphlets outside Woolworths without permission.

Some young[redacted] voters in Warrnambool were too afraid to wear their [redacted] T-shirts in case they should be targeted by these Plymouth people. Thanks for this opportunity."

"I would like to offer the following experiences:

- When setting up at the polling booth, the [redacted] volunteer arrived, and I immediately realised she was [redacted]. The interaction was pleasant but minimal, and I did not mention that I knew who she was, and she was soon joined by another member of the Corangamite Shire Council. The two took to discussing council business as they began to hand out how to vote cards for the [redacted]. I felt that this was an abuse of position, particularly for [redacted] and quickly looked up the regulations, to find that there was not one that forbid this practice. My concern was the influence elected officials on a local council were having on a federal election. They talked about what Wards they represented, interacted with voters in their official positions, with some being heard to greet her as "[redacted]". To have [redacted] Council members aligned so publicly with the [redacted] Party, and possible party members also brings into question the standing of the local council, when these people were not elected by the shire residents as [redacted] candidates.
- When at the polling place for scrutineering, I felt intimidated by a [redacted] party scrutineer who invaded personal space and made ongoing negative comments about other candidates. This person left after first preferences were counted and the other volunteer was fine in their interactions and remained until the end of counting. It would be advantageous in future if all who began scrutineering the counting were required to remain until the end, as this exacerbated my point below.
- At scrutineering of the counting, the [redacted] volunteers would not assist in overseeing the opening of boxes and the like, which meant that I was unable to scrutineer counting as officials required this oversite and the second signature on the paperwork. I felt this was a deliberate tactic to ensure that I could not scrutineer the counting, particularly of first preference votes."

"I thought that the pre polling area, while very busy at times, was well monitored. Allowances were made for the elderly and people with disabilities. I had two concerns related to:

- signage and
- persons being bullied by a Brethren.

Signage – Too many signs were put up at the back entrance in particular which hindered foot traffic movement. Suggestion - only one sign of reasonable size per political party be taped to the windows and not placed on the footpaths.
Persons being bullied – I reported the one incident that came to my attention to the person in charge and they handled the incident.

Polling Booth on election day went very smoothly. A concerning feature though is the number of people who did not know how to complete the green ballot card (i.e.) needed to place a number in **all** the boxes or how to fill in white ballot sheet of paper. The guidelines put out by the AEC are very clear ...it is a matter of getting people to read them."

"My main comment is the incessant mail outs filling our letterboxes containing appalling misinformation and character association from the [redacted] endorsed by local [redacted].
Gutter politics made mainstream."

"The only thing I would raise was the obvious involvement of the Brethren as [redacted] volunteers at Pre-poll in Torquay!"

"All went smoothly at the Noorat booth as far as I could see so I have nothing to contribute with regard to behaviour - good, bad or otherwise- at the booth.
I am concerned about the appallingly negative and 'attack the man and not the issue' approach that the [redacted] took with their mail outs during the election however. I am presuming VoW will be including this in the submission?"

"I completed two pre poll days in Colac without incident and was on duty on polling day in Terang and unfortunately experienced an aggressive voter late in the day. She spoke with a raised voice as she climbed the steps to the voting area, saying [redacted] was controlled by the [redacted] or [redacted] Party and I assured her that he was totally [redacted]. The "lady" then turned and came back towards me almost spitting in my face with her uncontrolled comments.
Another female volunteer from the [redacted] camp, who hadn't acknowledged me all day, came towards me along with another of our female volunteers as a show of solidarity.
The woman then turned and went in to vote and I moved to another area and didn't see her exit the booth."

"I volunteered to hand out how to vote cards for the [redacted] in the Wannon electorate at the last Federal Election. On the election day I was handing out how to vote cards at the main polling booth in Hamilton. I said to a man "[redacted]" as I held

out a how to vote card. The intended recipient stated "If you hand that to me, I will punch you in the face" then kept walking. He already had a [redacted] Party how to vote card in is hand. As he walked past the fellow next to me (handing out how to vote cards for the [redacted] Party) he said to him "good on you, mate." I was shocked. When I had gathered my wits I went to the person who seemed to be organising the [redacted] Party how to vote card folks. I told him what had occurred and noted that the person who spoke appreciatively to the man who threatened me was rapidly removed from his post and I saw him leave in his car.
I am a 58-year-old woman, short with a slight build. The threatening man was tall with a very solid build. I am fine, a bold and resilient woman and I will continue to actively participate in the political process. However, I was shocked by the words of the first man and appalled by the words of the second man.
I hope this is helpful for your enquiry."

" [I was] frustrated that the clearly illegal campaign signs at petrol stations in Hamilton could not be forcibly removed by the council because, as I understand it, due process would mean that a decision by council/AEC could only be made after election day.[I was also] annoyed that the aggressive behaviour of a supporter of [redacted] who was more than likely a member of the large contingent of Plymouth Brethren, was unable to face a sanction of any sort. Whilst he did not physically assault anyone, his aggressive style of adding a HTV brochure as the last piece of campaign literature a voter received, despite a [redacted] Party HTV already placed in the hands of the voter by another campaigner was overly intimidating. There were complaints to AEC staff, who then spoke to campaigners. However, nothing appeared enforceable.
A system that allows voters to seek out information, both written and spoken, about candidates needs to be preserved without the behaviour of a small minority placing, particularly elderly, voters under duress."

"My most common issue was with other volunteers not respecting the distance-from-the-polling-place rule, particularly the [redacted] volunteers but also sometimes others, which was potentially intimidating to voters."
There were some instances of obstruction where a [redacted] volunteer physically stood between me and a voter so I could not talk to them or offer them a leaflet."

"I was a volunteer for the [redacted] Campaign and I volunteered at an election booth.
My major concern during the election and at the booth was the nature of the political advertising. Some of it was factually untrue and to be honest, pretty disgusting.
It does not reflect well on us as a nation that we cannot argue our case without resorting to lies and character assassination. We are not demonstrating a mature democratic process to our children when this occurs.
In fact, lies and character assassination by political parties and individual politicians demonstrates that it's perfectly acceptable to behave this way and then we wonder why members of the general public resort to such behaviours over a range of contentious issues. We are seeing this play out in our society now.
I strongly believe that it should be against the law to lie in political advertising."

"1. I was approached by a voter who wanted to vote for [redacted] but she was confused about what to put in all the other boxes, as [redacted]'s How To Vote card did not direct any preferences. I explained to her the correct method was to continue numbering the remaining boxes 2, 3, 4 etc until she had numbered every box. She thanked me and carrying [redacted]'s HTV card with her she headed towards the entrance to vote. Right then a [redacted] party volunteer ran up beside the voter and told her to put a "2" in every other box - cunningly misadvising the voter in the hope she would cast an invalid vote. I reported this misconduct to the head booth overseer inside the booth who said there was nothing he could do about this behaviour and suggested I take it up with the [redacted], which I did not.
2. While handing out [redacted]'s HTV cards I chatted to people going in to vote, remaining at the required distance from the entry etc. I explained facts such as being an [redacted] [redacted] was beholden to no party but would be working directly for the people of Wannon. [redacted] reps verbally attacked me saying I was a liar and that I had no right to speak so politically to people!
3. The [redacted] erected multiple different slanderous images of [redacted] at the booth. It was nasty. [redacted]'s content was positive and on topic.
Thank you for caring about the quality of our election process."

"[I have a video] I took at the pre pol of the [redacted] volunteer who I believed was a Brethren. The person was doing the vote in the car and this person was leaning in and telling him where to put the numbers and in what order.
He was also quite aggressive at talking to the voters who were over the line and telling them how to vote in the Senate.
I did show the electoral staff on the day about his behaviour.
The [redacted] volunteers at the polling booth on election day were pretty reasonable. The only thing they tried was to rub on our bunting to make it come off. But when I said about it to him, he backed off and let it be.
Also, on election Day at Elliminyt we had some young boys (14-17) pull down and kick the [redacted] signs calling him a [redacted]. They came back three times. It was actually [redacted] ([redacted]) [[redacted]] who spoke to them and moved them on but they came back.
The Advance flyers that were sent out also had a big effect on misinformation that I saw from door knocking. Some people believed he was a [redacted], from this information."[5]

"The issues I would like to comment on are:
1. I had corflutes defaced and stolen from my yard - which means people entered my property in the night to do that.
2. I felt unsafe participating in legitimate and respectful campaigning online because of trolling and the total lack of safeguards or protections against bullying and lies. And I was so saddened to see the abuse and vitriol my fellow campaigners had to withstand, not to mention the candidate.
3. Voters have no protection from manipulation and mis/disinformation from information online, sent in the mailbox, handed out with door knockers, sent to institutions like schools, talked about on radio, placed up on billboards - the laws seem antiquated and not keeping up with changing nature and less formal forms/spaces where campaigns and elections are occurring.
4. There is limited safety and protection for candidates from harm.
5. At polling booths in Wannon, the disproportionate numbers of [redacted] volunteers to any other party was inappropriate - to the point where it was intimidating and obstructive.

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[5] [redacted]/

Thank you for the opportunity to participate. Our democracy is very precious and I don't take any of it for granted."

"I would like to make some comments about my experience with the last 2025 Federal Election with respect to the pre poll voting at Torquay Victoria. When I arrived along the footpath to the venue, I saw a large [redacted] branded van parked outside the venue. Two [redacted] (men) volunteers were stationed on the footpath. When I entered the car park for the venue (warehouse) I saw eight [redacted] volunteers. Four on either side of the path to the voting venue entrance. There was a [redacted] branded gazebo placed very close to the venue entrance. All other volunteers for other parties were trying to get a position in between this large group of [redacted] Party volunteers. It felt very uncomfortable to see so many volunteers looking like an army. The atmosphere was intimidating. A particularly rude man [a voter] made disparaging remarks to me and not one of the [redacted] male volunteers said a word. I would have expected that someone would have said that it was not appropriate to speak like that to anyone. To me it [the polling place] looked like a [redacted] Party venue with a small group of other people from other parties trying to get around the crowd of [redacted] volunteers. The [redacted] Party simply overwhelmed the site. I felt very relieved to be able to leave the site after my shift."

"Whilst I didn't encounter any aggression on pre-poll in Colac [another volunteer] was unlucky enough to have some yob from the [redacted] party yelling at the voters about a non-existent ute tax and how they needed to vote [redacted] to avoid it. Other HTV distributers either tried to rebuke him or ignored him. Either way his comments were lies and damaging to other candidates, yet nothing was done from an AEC point of view to eliminate the BS. Mind you I don't think the average AEC official has been trained in such negotiations and really shouldn't have to deal with this rubbish day in day out anyway. What annoyed me both at pre-poll and prior to the election being declared was the amount of mis-information, dis-information and straight out lies that were allowed to land in people's letterboxes, bombard their TV screens and be erected on billboards or on corflutes that were displayed enroute to the polling booths. As nothing can be done about these contraventions of electoral rules until after any election that is a chronic failure of the current electoral law and needs to be rectified immediately. With Advance no doubt waiting to pounce again at the next State or Federal election and AI now an insidious contender in the fake news mix something seriously has to be done to thwart the loss of truth in campaigning. That way lies madness along the lines of Trump's America where the truth gets called fake news and lies go unchallenged. As the ***Washington Post*** used to claim on its banner 'Democracy dies in Darkness' and then Jeff Besos took it out. We do not want Australia to go down that irretrievable route - we are better than that."

"Thank you for the opportunity to have input into this process
I was with three other [redacted] supporters at the Colac pre-poll booth handing out how to vote material and the [redacted] Party only had 2 reps there. One of them made a phone call and a "squad" of bulging-muscled gym boys in blue T shirts turned up.
I experienced aggressive behaviour from one of these men. I introduced myself to Luke and offered to shake hands. I have a firm handshake and he hurt my hand, squashing it and pumping my forearm back and forth. I then watched these men aggressively approaching voters before they had even turned off their car engines. I moved away from the area where the [redacted] were standing as I did not feel comfortable.

Are we mentioning the false information on materials and that spoken in interviews? Can we insist that the AEC be given the power to ban false information? Can we insist on honesty in elections to avoid what would otherwise be slander and libel? [redacted] seems to be the only person pushing for reform I love our democracy and will always work to ensure everyone has the right to express their desires at the ballot box."

"Firstly, the location chosen for Warrnambool was poor. these should be done well in advance crammed into that space. Something the AEC needs to address. It did, however, contribute to many of the problems faced by volunteers and to underhanded tactics used by the [redacted] party.
Early morning raids by [redacted] volunteers to bombard the Glasshouse walkway with banners and misleading posters, many of which were not approved material, contravened AEC rules. There must be clear guidelines and a number of placards for each party applied to every polling place for equitable representation.
On election day at the St Joseph's polling station, long swaths of [redacted] plastic banners came lose in the wind and blew onto the road and surrounding area, not one of the party members acted in securing this environmental hazard. Materials for use and the strict rules for display must be reviewed.
The AEC should have a designated staff member outside of pre poll to assist elderly and infirm so they do not have to queue. We were told we were not to assist the elderly, but AEC staff were not present to provide necessary aide. There should be a staff member outside scrutinising the proceedings at all times.
Another area of great concern is the influx of Hamilton people to man pre poll for the [redacted] party. Many of these people were paid and not volunteers. They had little to no training and were not very clear on their job at pre poll. I could mention the huge presence of The Brethren as [redacted] volunteers, but that's under scrutiny already.
What I would like to see for future Pre poll and election day stations are two people per position to hand out how to vote cards. This being a safety measure so that aggressive voters do not target individuals. I had an ugly experience and my closest buddy did not come to my aid. I was pinned against a glass wall and after a tirade of foul-mouthed abuse and aggression, a [redacted] volunteer came to my aid. I was very disappointed by the lack of action by my fellow volunteer. No one should be left as a target especially in the last week of what became an aggressive campaign.
We should back each other in a calm and supportive way. Having said this, I would volunteer in a heartbeat again and again to create a change for Wannon."

Recommendations from the Committee of Voices of Wannon

It is clear from this sample of volunteer experiences that the 2025 federal election in Wannon marked a new low in Australian electoral conduct.

It should be acknowledged by the Inquiry that these adverse experiences were all created by those acting for, representing, and or by actual members of the [redacted]. As far as we are aware, no other political party or candidate engaged in the rude, intimidating, false and other inappropriate behaviour during the campaign.

It seems to VoW that all these accounts of [redacted] deception, aggression and poor behaviour make the comments by [redacted] in the ***Warrnambool Standard*** on May 3 2025[6] risible:
"[redacted] *said it had been a "really positive campaign"."*

Indeed, VoW members would be very supportive of the Inquiry seeking testimony from [redacted] about his own, and his campaign team's, performance in the 2025 election. We would certainly like to hear from him about just where his campaign 'support' came from, and what he thinks about the forms that support took. We would also very much like to better understand what he meant by 'positive' - given his team's activities, attitude and performance.

It is our strong view that in the course of hearings for this inquiry, the Committee should consider seeking testimony from a range of people including voters, volunteers, lobbyists and candidates about the behaviour they experienced and exhibited during this campaign. Other electorates' experiences could also be reviewed: Goldstein springs to mind, but there will surely be others. VoW members would be willing to testify at such hearings.
We can assure the committee that while some of our volunteers were first timers in political campaigns, others of us have been politically active for many years.
None of us have ever experienced the sort of disruption, aggression and hostility as part of an election campaign before.

In addition to the actively hostile campaign tactics and behaviour displayed by the [redacted] team, the election campaign revealed several other problems and inadequacies in the conduct of the election. While these are real issues, it is also true that the behaviour detailed above served to highlight them as problems and may not have been so obvious had the behaviour of some on the campaign been better.

1. The selection of the site for Warrnambool pre-polling and polling day was poor and was made actually dangerous in a sense by the tactics of one group:
   "the location chosen for Warrnambool was poor. these should be done well in advance crammed into that space. Something the AEC needs to address. It did, however, contribute to many of the problems faced by volunteers and to underhanded tactics used by the [redacted] party".

[6] p.2

If such conduct is going to be allowed to continue in future in the name of faux 'free speech', different sites are needed and careful consideration needs to be given to their selection by the Australian Electoral Commission [AEC].

For example, the site for pre-polling and polling in Colac was a good choice – with a lot of space and no buildings close by creating a tunnel-like effect by one aggressive party. This did not prevent bullying and intimidatory tactics being adopted by the [redacted] Brethren campaign 'assistants' at Colac, but it did mean voters could move easily enough to avoid them.

2. Given the tactics exhibited across Wannon at pre-polling and on polling day in 2025, it may be necessary to amend the legislation and or regulations relating to the role of AEC staff at each pre-polling and polling place.

   It seems to us that at least one designated AEC staff member at each voting place needs greater legal authority to enforce existing AEC regulations – even in the face of intimidation, and to operate with a defined trigger at which time police are called to quell disruption and or intimidation of voters or volunteers.

   In general, we believe the AEC staff need more and better training, as well as a range of greater powers to combat these sorts of behaviour at polling places, and also for the AEC senior executives to issue fines and press releases quickly detailing false and misleading electoral material distributed by anyone, before and during election campaigns.

   Like almost all Australians, VoW has the highest respect for the AEC and we believe it needs the resources – legislative and financial – necessary to continue to perform the job it was designed to do. We believe that the AEC itself should testify at the inquiry's hearing so Committee members can learn what resources the AEC needs to continue to do the excellent job it does, in this new hostile electoral environment.

3. While this may prove very difficult, the Committee should consider making recommendations about the creation of new regulations relating to size and scope of electoral advertising and other electoral materials e.g. even HTV are no longer A5 but should be limited to that size in our opinion. Corflutes size and designated allocated spaces for their erection should perhaps also be regulated.

   VoW believes that some voters have felt intimidated and unsafe when attending polling places due to the number of overly pushy "volunteers" from some parties, and due to the sheer scale of campaign materials (eg: metres and metres of banners blocking access ways). We believe that legislation needs to be changed to ensure that voters feel safe and comfortable when coming to vote. There should be limits applied to the number of people and the amount of campaign material allowed at polling places, and the AEC must be given the powers and

resources to police these limits. For example, there could be a limit of two people and two standard size corflute signs per candidate per polling place entry point.

Another way of addressing the problem may be to limit and restrict tightly the amount of money any and all candidates can spend on election campaigns, and on what each spends it on, and that this should be revealed in real time by each candidate and MP as many [redacted] already do.

We note that, as we understand the 2024 partial electoral 'reforms', while the changes will severely limit SOME BUT NOT ALL candidates' fund-raising capacities, the [redacted] and the [redacted] retain unlimited access to their external funding bodies. VoW views the provisions which allow these profound inequalities as undemocratic and seeks them to be amended to be fair to all parties.

4. The best way, of course, to address some of the problems listed here would be properly legislate for truth in political advertising as proposed by [redacted] and others.

   As one VoW member put it:
   "In my local electorate of Wannon, there was a huge campaign of misinformation and disinformation that began well before any election announcement. In my opinion, content that would be illegal once the election is announced should also not be allowed to be published before the election announcement—for the same reasons it is not permitted once the election has been called.
   In the lead-up to the election, Wannon was saturated with flyers and advertising, much of which was propaganda. People were already 'over' the election before it had even been announced, due to the overwhelming amount of advertising material they had received. As a result, voters often didn't pay attention to information they received once the election was officially underway, having already been inundated. The misinformation and disinformation therefore played a role in shaping their understanding of the election. For this reason, rules around political advertising and information should apply at all times—not just in the final period before an election.
   Democracy should surely be based on informed decision-making.
   There is no place in democracy for lies."

The current government's failure to act on truth in political advertising when it commands such a majority in the House and could pass it in the Senate with the support of the [redacted] and Crossbench we believe shows that the current government is not truly interested in improving this aspect of our democracy

VoW would like to ask the [redacted] in particular, whether they are content to govern in a system which allows voters to be intimidated as Wannon voters and the volunteers from other political parties and organisations were during the 2025 federal election campaign? We can all see – right now in the US - where such behaviour is leading, and where legislative permission to legitimise intimidation can take us all.

In relation to T of R 4:
the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.

This term of reference seems perhaps to relate to the use of digital media in electioneering? If that is its intent, then yes new regulation is needed: see the comments about the need for new AEC powers above. Australian regulation of the algorithms used by social media companies is also required.

The Special Minister of State has also asked the Committee to consider the interaction with the following:

- *the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;*

We note that this Term of Reference 5 and those below, which Senator Farrell 'has asked the Committee [and therefore all Australians] to consider' are huge questions – broad and deep in scope.

In relation to T of R 5, it seems to us this request to 'consider in the context' does not in any way do justice, or give the necessary weight to, the need to understand the potentially undemocratic and completely unfair effects of some provisions of the *'the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament'*.

Given that many of the provisions of *'the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament'* do not come into effect until the next federal election due in 2028, we ask: how is it even possible to consider them in context?

VoW believes that this Term of Reference requires a separate and comprehensive Inquiry of its own, given that several of the provisions in those reforms create an unfair and unequal playing field for all seeking election to parliament EXCEPT candidates from the [redacted], [redacted] and [redacted].

Given the selective benefits provided by these arrangements, it is no surprise that it was those same parties who worked together to pass the legislation. It would be useful for such 'bi-partisanship' to be repeated in relation to both T of R 6 *'ongoing threats'* and 7 *'the composition of Parliament as a whole…'*. We note however that given the government's large majority in the House and the real possibility of the government co-operating with [redacted] and the Crossbench MPs in the Senate, such 'major' party cooperation, while it can be desirable, is not actually required.

In relation to T of R 6

- *reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and*

In our experience in Wannon the most serious import from 'foreign' sources was the aggressive and hostile tone and behaviour of [redacted] and his extended campaign team. Their tactics echoed those of Trump directly and are thus imported foreign threats.

VoW believes that this Term of Reference also requires a separate and comprehensive Inquiry of its own, involving serious examination of submissions from the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, and all security agencies. This T of R seems to us to overlap and integrate with T of R 4 the potential for digital interference in our electoral processes, and is too important to be somehow treated incidentally.

In relation to T of R 7

- *the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.*

One VoW member commented:
"Finally, bring in 4-year fixed terms so that
a) Policy and programs can actually be implemented and have a chance to run.
b) The country doesn't spend a third of the parliamentary cycle in constant election anticipation mode waiting for a date announcement - it's a waste of good parliamentary policy time - actual governing for the best outcome for the people parliamentarians represent.
c) A date isn't chosen opportunistically that will benefit the incumbent government."

VoW agrees. Unfortunately, we note that while state governments have been able to do this without fuss, the Australian Constitution requires a referendum for this reform to be achieved for the federal parliament. Given recent tactics in referenda by the [redacted] and [redacted], the necessary bipartisanship by the largest parties seems unlikely. This is to be regretted.

One VoW member suggested "It's not rocket science it just needs bipartisan good will to achieve this outcome."
Unfortunately, as Professor Anne Twomey advises, it IS somewhat 'rocket science-y'. She suggests a four-year fixed term for both House and Senate might work IF the reserve powers were dealt with effectively by a Constitutional Convention AND when there was committed and honoured support for such a referendum from both the larger parties/coalitions. See https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-pJywiihapA

VoW notes the calls by some for what could be more effective representation by reducing the size of the population allocated to each federal electorate. While we can see some sense in having the AEC reduce and redistribute electoral boundaries to include say 100,000 voters, we also see that the amount of work for the AEC, the likely resulting political disruption, and the increased cost of so many more federal MPs may

mean any government finds the idea unpalatable. That fact should not prevent the [redacted] government from considering it seriously.

VoW also believes that the pre-polling period of two weeks is too long and could be reduced to one week. People unable to vote in that period or on polling day can do a postal vote. The postal voting timeframe should be expanded to allow more time. If this requires legislation to be amended so that the election period is longer (to allow the AEC time to close candidate nominations and complete all necessary administrative work to prepare postal voting paperwork) then that should be done. A longer postal voting period would ensure that people who are travelling are not disenfranchised – as it stands, some people are not able to exercise their right to vote because of the limited postal vote timeframe and limited access to overseas polling places.

Legislation needs to be amended to prohibit parties from sending out "postal vote application forms" which are actually returned via that political party, and are clearly an underhanded and misleading data harvesting practice.

In conclusion VoW thanks the Australian Parliament for the opportunity to make it aware of the newly hostile atmosphere during the 2025 federal election campaign in Wannon. This was new, different and unwelcome compared to the 2022 campaign here. It is clear to us that one person his party and associates were responsible for creating the hostile tone of the Wannon campaign, although it is certainly true that the same organisations contributed to the same negative atmosphere elsewhere around Australia.

While our preferred candidate was not successful in Wannon, we were pleased and proud to note that the Australian electorate voted resoundingly to reject that aggressive and hostile approach to democracy imported from the US and adopted by the [redacted] in many places.

We in VOW will continue to reject negative, smear-based campaigning in favour of a positive and inclusive approach.

APPENDIX

1. [redacted] CAMPAIGN CODE OF CONDUCT

Campaign Code of Conduct

As members of the [redacted], we hold ourselves to the highest standards. By signing up as a volunteer you agree to abide by the campaign values and this code of conduct.

Our values are authenticity, positivity, respect, trust, integrity & fun :)

As volunteers we agree to:

- Respect the rights and opinions of others.
- Work as a team.
- Take care of ourselves and others.
- Do everything we can to make the campaign positive and fun.
- Use electronic communication with care.
- Expect high standards of ourselves and others.
- Focus on the outcomes and the campaign goal to WIN!

We will hold ourselves to the highest standards

We will display integrity at all times and will respect the rights and opinions of others. We will focus on policies not personalities, and positives not negatives. We will do everything we can to make the campaign a positive and fun experience for all. Above all, we will always be polite.

We will focus on outcomes

While all opinions are valid, in order to achieve our goals we understand that decisions will be made based on achieving the best end result. We won't make things personal, or take things personally. We trust in the leadership team to set the best course possible, and once the campaign leaders make a decision we will support those decisions.

We will respect and learn from each other

All our systems must be optimised to help volunteers on the front line make the biggest possible impact. Volunteers who are highly productive can sometimes be too enthusiastic. If over-enthusiasm and directness turns into real disruption, affecting the campaign's capacity to achieve our goals, we reserve our right to request a change in the behaviour of, or even dismiss, disruptive volunteers from the campaign.

We will not get into email trouble

If there is disagreement in an email or other electronic thread, we will quickly move to a real-time conversation on the phone or in person. It's easy for tone or intent to be misconstrued online. We won't write anything that would embarrass us if it were made public.

We will work as a team

Our team needs everyone at every level to bring suggestions to the table for making our work better. We will only win if everyone contributes the best ideas, offers constructive criticism when appropriate, engages in problem solving, and helps anticipate future problems. That said,

it's up to the campaign leaders to make decisions, and for the rest of the team to align with those decisions. Fast and effective decision-making can't happen by consensus, but it should be informed by all the smart people we have working on the campaign.

We will be grateful for the opportunity

This is an amazing team and a huge opportunity to get an independent MP in Wannon who will truly represent our community voice. We will strive to hold each other and ourselves accountable for doing everything possible to win the election. If we fall short then we will do it with a spirit of forgiveness and generosity. We will be honoured to be involved and do our work with a sense of gratitude and fun.

We will take care of ourselves and others

We will be careful celebrating and not drink and drive. We won't drink at all if we are responsible for drivin[redacted] We will never work alone when helping at public events, hubs, or doorknocking, and will let our area volunteer coordinator know if we need a break.

Reporting concerns

If any volunteers have any concerns about the behaviour of others involved in the campaign, or other issues of a similar nature, the process for resolving issues is as follows:

1. In the first instance, discuss the issue with your area volunteer coordinator.
2. If you are unable to resolve the issue with your area volunteer coordinator, you cannot contact them, the concern involves your area volunteer coordinator, or you do not know who your area volunteer coordinator is, then conta[redacted] Lead Organiser, a[redacted]r on[redacted]
3. If you are still unable to resolve the issue, contact [redacted], Campaign Coordinator, at [redacted] or or[redacted]

Please note that while the campaign leaders will listen to and respect the views of all volunteers, they reserve the right to make the final decision on all matters.